

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

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DOMINANT JUDGMENT	THE FEDERAL POSTURE JUST CHANGED

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

This issue of **The Alamo Threat Brief** aligns to the week of **3 May 2026** and assesses a threat environment in which the U.S. federal cyber posture itself shifted within seven days. **CISA's CI Fortify initiative, the Five Eyes joint guidance on agentic AI, and the AHA – Joint Commission Cyber Resilience Readiness program** are not three separate stories. They are one story told three times: the threat picture has crossed a line that federal agencies are no longer willing to absorb on behalf of operators, and the design assumptions for Texas critical infrastructure, healthcare, and AI workloads have all been moved at once. Layered on top of that posture shift, the Iranian OT-targeting tempo against U.S. water and energy operators continues at the elevated baseline established after Operation Epic Fury, DOJ accelerated DPRK laptop-farm sentencing to near-monthly cadence, and perimeter edge-device exploitation by Akira and successor ransomware groups remains the dominant initial-access vector against Texas mid-market and DIB suppliers. The central analytic judgment this week is that Texas boards are no longer being asked to prepare for these conditions. They are being told what they will be expected to prove they have prepared for.

Decision 1 — CI Fortify Isolation Readiness

If your operations depend on continuous third-party vendor, OT supplier, or cloud connectivity, decide this week whether your continuity plans answer the new federal question: can this organization deliver essential services for 30, 60, or 90 days while disconnected from IT, OT, and third-party networks? CISA has now told critical infrastructure operators that this is the baseline expectation, not the stretch goal.

Decision 2 — Agentic AI Inventory and Authority

If your organization has deployed any agentic AI capability — Copilot, Salesforce Agentforce, internal agents, or vendor-embedded agents — decide whether you can produce, before the next board meeting, an inventory of every agent, its permissions, its identity controls, and the human-in-the-loop checkpoints for high-impact actions. The Five Eyes guidance just made this a board-level governance question.

Decision 3 — Remote Workforce Identity Assurance

If your organization hires remote engineers, developers, or technical contractors, decide whether your identity verification, geolocation monitoring, video interviewing, and laptop-shipment endpoint controls will withstand the regulatory and reputational test when the next DPRK indictment lands. DOJ has now sentenced eight U.S. nationals in five months for facilitating these schemes. The cadence is monthly, not quarterly.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

The most consequential development this week is not a new adversary action. It is the synchronized movement of three independent federal authorities from advisory language to enforcement language inside seven days. On **1 May 2026, the Five Eyes intelligence community published its first joint security guidance for agentic AI systems**, warning that autonomous agents capable of acting on networks are already inside critical infrastructure with permissions most operators cannot adequately monitor. On **4 May 2026, the American Hospital Association and The Joint Commission jointly launched the Cyber Resilience Readiness program**, attaching hospital cyber-resilience assessment to accreditation-adjacent processes for the first time. On **6 May 2026, CISA announced CI Fortify**, instructing critical infrastructure operators to plan for delivering essential services under disconnection from IT, OT, and third-party networks for weeks to months at a time, citing Salt Typhoon and Volt Typhoon by name.

This kind of synchronized posture shift is rare in the unclassified domain. It typically happens when the people who see the classified picture have decided the unclassified posture is no longer adequate to the threat. The threat picture itself did not change this week. The expectation about what operators are supposed to be able to do about it did. For Texas, where the largest concentration of AI data-center interconnection requests in the country meets a 226-gigawatt ERCOT large-load queue and a four-sector critical infrastructure economy, that expectation lands on more boards faster than in any other state.

Bottom line: Texas energy, healthcare, financial services, and defense leaders should plan now as if the next twelve to eighteen months bring sector-specific regulatory expectations built on this week's foundation. The window for posture upgrades made on the operator's own timeline is closing. Acting now is cheaper than reacting later, and reacting later is the historical pattern this guidance was written to prevent.

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that it is **likely** (55–80%) that CI Fortify guidance forms the basis for sector-specific regulatory expectations applicable to Texas energy, water, and healthcare operators within 12–18 months. State regulators, Texas DIR, ERCOT reliability standards, and CMS hospital conditions of participation are all candidate vectors. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: CISA public statements via Acting Director Andersen; sector risk management agency precedent; consistent multi-source reporting across FedScoop, SC Media, and AHA News. Primary uncertainty: the timeline by which advisory language becomes binding rule varies by sector and regulator and is not publicly committed.

KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that there is an **even chance** (40–55%) that at least one publicly disclosed agentic AI security incident affecting a Texas data center, hyperscaler tenant, or downstream enterprise customer becomes public within the next 6–9 months. **MODERATE**

CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Five Eyes guidance acknowledging deployed agents already operating with insufficient governance; industry deployment velocity; absence of mature detection tooling. Primary uncertainty: agentic AI security incidents may surface as ordinary operational outages or vendor incidents without explicit agent-attribution; the public disclosure pathway is not yet standardized.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas data-center operators and their hyperscale tenants should pre-position incident-response language and disclosure posture for an agent-attributed event before one occurs.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that it is **likely** (55–80%) that at least one publicly named DPRK IT-worker victim company in the next six months will be a Texas-headquartered firm. The base rate makes Texas a near-certain geographic exposure given more than 100 historically named victim companies and the concentration of remote technical hiring across Austin, Dallas, and Houston. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Enforcement cadence (eighth U.S. national sentenced in five months); geographic distribution of historically named victim companies; remote-work hiring patterns concentrated in Texas metros. Primary uncertainty: federal investigators do not always disclose victim company identities publicly; some Texas exposure will surface only through Treasury or SEC filings.

KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that it is **likely** (55–80%) that Iranian OT-targeting tempo against U.S. water and energy operators persists at the current elevated baseline through at least the end of Q3 2026. The 7 April joint advisory has not been retired or downgraded; the Iran – Israel – U.S. conflict environment has not resolved in a direction that reduces this pressure. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: Sustained federal advisory posture; persistence of the post-Operation Epic Fury conflict environment; observed Iranian VSAT/Starlink operational continuity per Unit 42. Primary uncertainty: whether a Q3 geopolitical inflection produces de-escalation or sharper escalation is not predictable from current open reporting.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Texas energy, water, and petrochemical operators should sustain the heightened OT vigilance posture through end of Q3 regardless of news cycle attention to Iran.

KJ-5

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that it is **almost certain** (95–99%) that perimeter edge devices (VPN, firewall, gateway) remain the dominant ransomware initial-access vector against Texas mid-market manufacturers, healthcare practices, and DIB suppliers through the remainder of 2026.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: 2026 At-Bay InsurSec Report (SonicWall present in 86% of Akira incidents; Akira 40%+ of all ransomware claims); sustained Qilin and The Gentlemen targeting patterns; pace of CISA Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog additions for edge-device CVEs throughout April–May 2026. Primary uncertainty: which specific edge-device CVE dominates the next six months is not predictable, but the category of attack vector is.

Section II

What Changed This Week

CI Fortify — The Isolation Mandate

On **6 May 2026**, **CISA announced the CI Fortify initiative**, urging critical infrastructure operators to plan for delivering essential services under emergency isolation — potentially for months. The agency emphasized the goal of maintaining service delivery even after disconnection from IT, OT, and third-party connections, with the initiative specifically citing Salt Typhoon and Volt Typhoon as the operational threat picture driving the guidance. CISA Acting Director Nick Andersen framed the program as "allowing safe operations for weeks to months while isolated" from IT networks and third-party tools.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

This is the operational translation of the Volt Typhoon pre-positioning warning that has been building since 2024. The federal government is now telling operators that the design assumption is no longer "if attacked, recover quickly" — it is "if attacked, operate for weeks while disconnected from your vendors." For Texas energy, healthcare, and water operators, this is a procurement, contracting, and architecture problem before it is a cyber problem.

Five Eyes Agentic AI Guidance — First Coordinated Multi-Government Statement

On **1 May 2026**, **CISA, NSA, ASD ACSC, the Canadian Centre for Cyber Security, NCSC-NZ, and NCSC-UK jointly published *Careful Adoption of Agentic AI Services***. The guidance warns that agents capable of taking real-world actions on networks are already inside critical infrastructure, and most organizations are granting them far more access than they can safely monitor or control. The agencies recommend that each agent carry a verified, cryptographically secured identity, use short-lived credentials, encrypt all communications with other agents and services, and require human approval for high-impact actions.

ASSESSMENT

Texas hosts the largest concentration of large-load data center interconnection requests in North America. ERCOT is tracking 410 GW of large loads seeking interconnection, of which 87% are data centers. The agentic AI workloads driving that demand are the same workloads the Five Eyes just flagged as ungoverned. The strategic terrain risk and the cybersecurity governance risk are the same risk, viewed from two angles.

AHA & Joint Commission Launch Cyber Resilience Readiness Program

On **4 May 2026**, **the American Hospital Association and The Joint Commission jointly launched the Cyber Resilience Readiness program**, formalizing hospital cyber-resilience assessment in a way that ties to accreditation-adjacent processes. The program follows three years of escalating cyber incidents against U.S. hospitals and the post-Change Healthcare recognition that cyber resilience is now operationally inseparable from patient safety. Texas hospital systems — from Texas Medical Center in Houston to the JBSA-Lackland medical complex, UT-affiliated systems, and rural critical-access hospitals — should expect cyber-resilience readiness questions to migrate from CISO-level to board-level within the quarter.

DPRK Laptop-Farm Enforcement Accelerates — 7th and 8th Sentences in Five Months

On **6 May 2026**, **DOJ announced the sentencing of Matthew Knoot (Nashville) and Erick Ntekereze Prince (New York)** — each to 18 months — for facilitating DPRK remote IT-worker schemes. These

represent the seventh and eighth sentences of U.S.-based "laptop farmers" secured in the last five months as part of the DPRK RevGen: Domestic Enabler Initiative. Two-thirds of public sentences in this enforcement campaign have landed in the last five months. The cadence has shifted from quarterly to roughly monthly. FBI Assistant Director Brett Leatherman: "Hosting laptops for DPRK IT workers is a federal crime which directly impacts our national security."

Iran — OT Targeting Tempo Holds at Elevated Baseline

The 7 April 2026 joint advisory on Iran-affiliated APT targeting of Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley PLCs across U.S. water, wastewater, energy, and government services has not been retired or downgraded. Following Operation Epic Fury (28 February 2026), Iran-linked threat actors transitioned to VSAT services through Starlink and other providers to maintain operational tempo. Stryker Corporation's global Microsoft environment was disrupted by an Iran-claimed attack, with its Lifenet emergency-responder data system rendered non-functional. The 47-day Iranian internet outage ended in mid-April with restored access to limited segments of the population, but the cyber operational tempo against U.S. critical infrastructure has not degraded.

Texas Healthcare — Killeen-based Practice Discloses Breach

On **30 April 2026**, Killeen, Texas-based Integrated Pain Associates disclosed a **February 2026 data security incident**. The forensic review confirmed unauthorized network access on or around 24 February 2026, and that patient data may have been accessed or acquired. The Killeen incident demonstrates that mid-size Texas healthcare practices — not just large hospital systems — remain firmly inside the ransomware and data-theft targeting set. The four-healthcare-provider breach disclosure cluster from late April underscores that healthcare attacker selection in 2026 is driven by exposure and exploitability, not by organization size.

Section III

Adversary Activity Update

China (PRC) — Strategic Terrain Pressure Intensifies

What Happened: CI Fortify is the U.S. government's clearest public acknowledgment to date that Volt Typhoon and Salt Typhoon access is presumed, not theoretical. Volt Typhoon actors have been observed maintaining access and footholds within some victim IT environments for at least five years. PRC zero-day exploitation against edge devices and third-party providers continues at scale.

Why It Matters: The targeting calculus is pre-positioning for disruption during a Taiwan or other regional crisis. Texas concentrates the energy, AI compute, financial clearing, and defense production capacity that pre-positioning logic prizes.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Any Texas operator running on assumed-clean networks, vendor remote-access lifelines, or unsegmented IT-to-OT pathways is operating against an adversary the U.S. government now publicly assumes is already inside U.S. critical infrastructure.

ASSESSMENT

ESCALATING (sustained from prior issue). The structural pressure has not changed; the federal posture acknowledging it has.

Iran — OT Pressure Sustained, Geopolitical Driver Unresolved

What Happened: The 7 April joint advisory on Iranian APT targeting of Rockwell Automation PLCs remains active. Iran-linked actors are using VSAT/Starlink relays to sustain operational tempo. Stryker and Chime Financial incidents both trace into the post-Operation Epic Fury Iranian retaliatory campaign.

Why It Matters: Iran has demonstrated willingness to convert geopolitical pressure into operational disruption against U.S. critical infrastructure. The threshold for escalation is now empirically lower than it was a year ago.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas operators of energy, water, petrochemical, and industrial infrastructure who have not yet hardened PLC access, segmented OT environments, or validated manual fallback procedures are operating with known, unaddressed risk. That is a board-level accountability question.

ASSESSMENT

ESCALATING (sustained — no de-escalation signal observed).

DPRK — Enforcement and Tradecraft Both Accelerating

What Happened: Treasury and DOJ enforcement on the IT-worker scheme is now running at near-monthly cadence. Tradecraft is migrating: Jasper Sleet operations use artificial intelligence to enable identity fabrication, social engineering, and long-term operational persistence at low cost. Lazarus Group continues to dominate cryptocurrency theft globally, with the FBI confirming the \$1.5 billion Bybit theft as the largest crypto exchange compromise on record.

Why It Matters: The DPRK insider-adjacent risk is no longer abstract for any sector that hires remote engineering or technical talent. Texas concentrates that hiring profile across Austin, Dallas, and Houston.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Defense contractors, AI firms, fintechs, and cleared-personnel employers face a converging exposure: cybersecurity, counterintelligence, and sanctions compliance are now the same problem when viewed through this vector.

ASSESSMENT

SUSTAINED at high tempo. Enforcement cadence acceleration is the new data point.

Russia — Hactivist Proxies and APT Targeting Both Persistent

What Happened: Russian APT targeting of the U.S. and Canada increased in 2025 with techniques optimized for stealth, deniability, and durability. Pro-Russia hactivist groups continue to pose a substantial and unpredictable threat, notably to OT environments. The Waterfall Threat Report 2026 documented a near-miss event at Polish distributed generation infrastructure pointing to Russian nation-state activity.

Why It Matters: Russia does not need to specifically target Texas to generate Texas-level damage. The behavioral escalation model being tested against European infrastructure is the leading indicator for U.S. exposure.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas organizations in energy, logistics, manufacturing, and finance remain exposed to a mature Russia-based criminal ecosystem capable of supply-chain compromise, credential theft, and identity abuse at scale.

ASSESSMENT

SUSTAINED. Behavioral escalation in Europe remains a forward warning model.

Criminal Ecosystem — Industrialized Edge-Device Exploitation

What Happened: Akira's 2025 dominance via SonicWall exploitation has not broken in early 2026. The 2026 At-Bay InsurSec Report confirmed that 73% of ransomware attacks in 2025 started with a VPN, SonicWall accounted for one in three ransomware claims, and Akira alone represented more than 40% of all ransomware claims. Qilin and The Gentlemen are the rising volume leaders. The Gentlemen expanded from 35 victims in Q4 2025 to 182 in Q1 2026 — the second most active group.

Why It Matters: The attacker calculus is no longer "who do I want to hit." It is "which device is exposed." Industry, size, and security budget have become less predictive than the brand of firewall or VPN on the perimeter.

Business Risk (Texas Lens): Texas mid-market manufacturers, defense suppliers, energy services firms, and healthcare practices use SonicWall, Fortinet, and similar perimeter devices at high concentration. Edge-device exposure is now the single most predictive ransomware-claim variable.

ASSESSMENT

ESCALATING (volume and concentration). The criminal ecosystem is becoming more concentrated, faster, and more device-targeting.

Section IV

Sector Watchpoints — Texas Focus

Energy ERCOT / OT / Grid

What changed: CI Fortify directly addresses electricity-sector operational continuity under disconnection. Texas grid operators face the additional pressure of approximately 226 GW of large-load customers in the ERCOT interconnection queue — nearly quadruple end-of-2024 levels — with about 77% from large data centers aiming to connect by 2030.

Why it matters locally: ERCOT's projected demand growth and the federal isolation mandate pull in opposite directions. Data-center growth assumes continuous, high-bandwidth, vendor-rich operations. CI Fortify assumes the opposite is achievable. The reconciliation problem will land on operators, utilities, and large-load customers simultaneously. **Cross-sector risk:** Energy disruption cascades to healthcare, water, finance, and telecommunications within hours, not days. A 2015 NERC exercise estimated concentrated grid attacks could produce \$250 billion to \$1 trillion in economic impact — figures substantially higher today.

Healthcare Hospitals / Practices / Data	What changed: AHA and The Joint Commission jointly launched the Cyber Resilience Readiness program on 4 May 2026. Killeen-based Integrated Pain Associates disclosed a February 2026 breach on 30 April. Why it matters locally: Texas hospital systems — including those operating within the JBSA-Lackland medical complex, the Texas Medical Center, UT-affiliated systems, and rural critical-access hospitals — should expect cyber-resilience readiness questions to migrate from CISO-level to board-level within the quarter. Mid-size Texas healthcare practices remain firmly inside the targeting set. Cross-sector risk: Healthcare disruption translates immediately into ED diversions, surgical postponements, and Medicare regulatory exposure, with downstream consequences for payment rails, supply chain, and family employer obligations.
Financial Banking / Fintech / Vendors	What changed: No new Texas-headquartered financial sector incident this week, but the litigation pipeline from prior incidents continues. Chime Financial's 1 April outage and Frost Bank class-action proceedings reinforce that the failure mode is the third-party vendor, not the bank itself. Why it matters locally: Texas regional banks, credit unions, and fintechs serving Texas customers face the same vendor-concentration exposure that produced the Frost incident. The financial sector lesson of 2026 so far is that "our network was not breached" is no longer an adequate defense before regulators or litigants. Cross-sector risk: Financial-sector disruption interacts with energy (utility billing), healthcare (revenue cycle), and DIB (contractor payment) within the same operational day.
Defense / DIB Contractors / Cleared / Personnel	What changed: DOJ accelerated DPRK laptop-farm enforcement to near-monthly cadence with the 6 May sentencings. The Texas DIB footprint — JBSA, Lockheed Fort Worth, BAE, L3Harris, and the broader San Antonio cyber ecosystem — is uniquely positioned to absorb both the regulatory pressure and the workload demand. Why it matters locally: A San Antonio-headquartered defense contractor running agentic AI workloads on a Texas data-center build, employing remote IT contractors, is sitting at the intersection of three federal enforcement priorities at once: CI Fortify, Five Eyes agentic AI, and DPRK IT-worker enforcement. Cross-sector risk: A cleared-contractor counterintelligence event has political consequences that exceed the cyber consequences and can take months to fully scope.
AI / Data Centers Compute / Cloud / Agents	What changed: Five Eyes agentic AI guidance landed during a week of accelerating federal attention to AI security architecture. The guidance explicitly flags that agents are already inside critical infrastructure with insufficient governance. Why it matters locally: Texas data centers are not just commercial infrastructure. They are housing workloads that touch defense, financial clearing, healthcare records, and AI training pipelines for national security applications. The intersection of ERCOT load growth, agentic AI deployment velocity, and federal scrutiny is concentrated in this state more than anywhere else in North America. Cross-sector risk: AI infrastructure disruption or compromise cascades immediately into energy (compute demand), finance (algorithmic and payment systems), healthcare (AI-assisted diagnostics), and DIB (classified-adjacent AI workloads).

Section V

Priority Intelligence Requirements — Weekly Update

PIR 1 Foreign cyber pre-positioning in Texas energy and water infrastructure [*↑ Rising*]

- Watch CISA emergency directives specific to ERCOT, Texas DIR, or Texas utility vendor supply chains
- Watch PUCT large-load approval timelines and grid equipment supply-chain disclosures
- Watch for sector-specific CI Fortify implementation guidance applied to Texas operators

CI Fortify is the most consequential collection development this quarter for this PIR. CISA is now explicitly designing for a future in which PRC pre-positioned access is presumed and recovery cycles are measured in months. This PIR remains the highest-priority collection focus for Liberty CTI in 2026.

PIR 2 Iranian OT targeting of Texas industrial operators [*→ Stable-Elevated*]

- Watch Censys, Shodan, and Greynoise data on Texas-resident internet-exposed PLCs
- Watch for new Iran-affiliated tradecraft variants moving from Unitronics to Rockwell to other vendor stacks
- Watch for Q3 2026 geopolitical inflection points that could drive Iranian escalation or de-escalation

Iranian APT tempo against Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley PLCs remains at the elevated baseline established after Operation Epic Fury. The April joint advisory has not been retired. The geopolitical driver has not de-escalated.

PIR 3 DPRK IT-worker infiltration of Texas employers [*↑ Accelerating*]

- Watch DOJ indictments and sentencings for named Texas-headquartered victim employers
- Watch Treasury OFAC designations affecting Texas technology and defense contractor labor supply chains
- Watch SEC 8-K filings for material cybersecurity incidents tied to remote-worker identity events

DOJ's near-monthly enforcement cadence and Treasury's continued OFAC designations confirm sustained federal pressure on this vector. Tradecraft migration toward AI-enabled identity fabrication via Jasper Sleet operations elevates the difficulty of detection.

PIR 6 Vendor and third-party concentration risk in Texas finance and healthcare [*→ Sustained*]

- Watch Texas Attorney General breach notification filings for shared-vendor patterns
- Watch class-action discovery for evidence of common third-party processors across multiple Texas institutions
- Watch for vendor-side OFAC or FTC actions affecting Texas customer-data pipelines

Frost Bank class-action proceedings and Chime Financial outage litigation pipeline continue to crystallize the vendor-concentration failure mode. The structural exposure is independently verified and does not depend on a single new incident this week.

PIR 9 AI and data-center security governance maturity in Texas [*↑ New Federal Pressure*]

- Watch CISA agentic AI implementation guidance for sector-specific applications
- Watch hyperscaler and major SaaS vendor disclosures regarding agent identity and governance posture
- Watch for first publicly attributed agentic AI security incident affecting Texas infrastructure

Five Eyes agentic AI guidance is the first coordinated multi-government statement on this category. Texas concentrates the deployment surface this guidance addresses. Liberty CTI elevates this PIR to active monitoring status.

Section VI

Executive Warning Indicators

Observable signals over the next 7–14 days. Any confirmed trigger should be treated as a decision-forcing event for the relevant sector.

W-1 Texas-named victim in any DPRK IT-worker indictment or sentencing announcement — confirms a Texas-headquartered employer is inside the DOJ enforcement pipeline; triggers immediate workforce identity audit and counsel engagement.

W-2 CISA emergency directive citing CI Fortify language and naming ERCOT, Texas DIR, or Texas hospital systems — confirms the guidance has transitioned into binding sector-specific expectations; highest-urgency trigger for Texas critical infrastructure operators.

W-3 Public OT disruption at a Texas water utility, municipal energy provider, or industrial site — confirms either Iranian escalation or criminal-proxy spillover; triggers immediate OT isolation and manual-fallback validation across the sector.

W-4 ERCOT or PUCT filing referencing cybersecurity continuity requirements for large-load (data center) interconnection — first regulatory expression of CI Fortify principles applied to data center customers; triggers contract and architecture review.

W-5 Class-action filing against a Texas bank or fintech tied to a third-party vendor breach — extends the Frost/Chime litigation pattern; triggers immediate vendor-disclosure-clause review for any Texas regional financial institution.

W-6 The Joint Commission survey finding referencing cyber-resilience readiness at a Texas hospital — confirms the AHA program has transitioned into accreditation-relevant practice; triggers C-suite engagement with the program ahead of any local survey.

W-7 Treasury OFAC designation affecting a Texas-headquartered company in defense, semiconductors, or energy — signals either DPRK, Iran, or PRC enforcement spillover into Texas industrial base; triggers sanctions compliance and supply-chain review.

W-8 Publicly disclosed agentic AI security incident at a hyperscaler with Texas data-center exposure — first concrete materialization of the Five Eyes warning; triggers cross-tenant exposure review for any Texas enterprise using shared agent infrastructure.

Section VII

Executive Implications & Recommended Actions

1 — Produce a 30-Day CI Fortify Readiness Statement

Direct your CIO and CISO to produce, within 30 days, a one-page CI Fortify readiness statement answering the new baseline question: can this organization deliver essential services for 30, 60, or 90 days while disconnected from third-party vendor networks? The answer becomes the architectural baseline for the next planning cycle.

What happens if you get this wrong: you discover your actual continuity posture in the middle of a cyber event rather than before one, and you discover it in front of regulators who now have a federal framework against which to grade you.

2 — Inventory and Permission-Audit Every Agentic AI Capability

If your organization has deployed any agentic AI capability — Copilot, GitHub Copilot Workspace, Salesforce Agentforce, vendor-embedded agents, or internal agents — require an inventory and a permission audit before the next board meeting. Treat any agent without a verified cryptographic identity and a kill switch as a finding.

What happens if you get this wrong: the Five Eyes guidance becomes evidence in the post-incident investigation that you had been put on notice and did not act.

3 — Harden Remote-Worker Identity Controls Against the DPRK Pattern

Direct HR and security to review remote-IT-worker hiring controls against the DPRK indicators published in DOJ and Wilson Sonsini guidance: identity verification, live video interviews, geolocation consistency for remote logins, laptop-shipment endpoint validation, and payroll routing anomaly monitoring. **What happens if you get this wrong:** you create a sanctions compliance exposure, a counterintelligence failure, and an insider-access risk that may already exist inside your organization.

4 — Re-Validate OT Isolation and PLC Access Pathways

For Texas operators with internet-connected industrial control systems, re-verify that no Rockwell Automation/Allen-Bradley PLC, HMI, or SCADA display is internet-exposed. Apply the April 2026 joint advisory mitigations even if you applied them in April. The Iranian targeting tempo has not degraded. **What happens if you get this wrong:** Iran or a criminal proxy turns an unaddressed OT exposure into an operational outage with safety implications under conditions that are very likely to persist through Q3 2026.

5 — Confirm Edge-Device Posture and Migration Credential Hygiene

Confirm SonicWall, Fortinet, Ivanti, and Cisco edge-device firmware is current; rotate every credential carried over from any prior firmware migration; enforce phishing-resistant MFA on every VPN path. **What happens if you get this wrong:** you become the next mid-market entry in the At-Bay InsurSec Report's Akira/SonicWall pattern, with an average ransom demand of \$1.2 million and litigation exposure on top of operational disruption.

6 — Pre-Position Hospital Cyber-Resilience Readiness Posture

For Texas healthcare operators, pre-position a Cyber Resilience Readiness response posture before The Joint Commission engagement reaches your facility. The program is new; the expectation is not. Texas hospital systems should engage now rather than during their next survey cycle. **What happens if you get this wrong:** a finding becomes part of your accreditation record before your team has time to absorb the framework.

7 — Brief the Board on the Federal Posture Shift in Plain Language

This week's CI Fortify, Five Eyes, and AHA developments are a single board-level governance story. The frame is the federal government is no longer asking; it is telling. The audit committee or risk committee is the right venue. **What happens if you get this wrong:** your board operates on a risk posture that does not reflect the federal expectations now in effect, and executives find themselves without institutional support when an incident forces escalation.

Section VIII

Analyst's Note

ANALYST'S NOTE

I spent thirty years producing intelligence for the people who had to decide. I watched the gap between when a warning existed and when the right person received it close, sometimes in time and sometimes too late. Every major infrastructure failure of consequence had a gap-to-decision problem at its center.

This week was unusual. Three federal authorities moved within seven days from telling critical infrastructure what the threat looked like to telling it what to be ready to do about it. That kind of synchronized posture shift is rare. It happens when the people who see the classified picture have decided the unclassified posture is no longer adequate to the threat.

I am writing this from San Antonio. The 35th Intelligence Squadron is at JBSA, minutes from where I sit. The grid I am warning about powers this city. The hospitals are the ones that take care of my family. This is not distant analysis.

If you are sitting on a board or running a Texas company in energy, healthcare, finance, or the defense industrial base, the warning that arrived this week is not addressed to a federal agency. It is addressed to you. **The decision is the same whether you receive it from me or from CISA. The difference is timing. Do not hand that timing back to the adversary.**

Section IX — Sourcing

Source Notes

OPEN SOURCE BASIS — ATB-2026-9 — WEEK OF 3 MAY 2026

CISA CI Fortify initiative announcement

[AHA News coverage](#)

Five Eyes joint agentic AI security guidance

[CISA release](#)

AHA & The Joint Commission Cyber Resilience Readiness program

[AHA News \(related coverage\)](#)

DOJ DPRK IT-worker laptop-farm sentencings

[DOJ release](#)

FBI / CISA / NSA / EPA / DOE / USCYBERCOM joint advisory on Iranian PLC exploitation

[IC3 advisory \(PDF\)](#)

Palo Alto Unit 42 Iran cyber escalation threat brief

[Unit 42 brief](#)

Integrated Pain Associates (Killeen, TX) breach disclosure

[HIPAA Journal report](#)

At-Bay 2026 InsurSec Report — Ransomware infrastructure analysis

[At-Bay InsurSec coverage](#)

ERCOT Long-Term Load Forecast & large-load queue reporting

[ERCOT forecast release](#)

National Law Review — CISA Iran advisory analysis (Stryker, Chime)

[National Law Review article](#)

Liberty CTI standing analytical baseline

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: The U.S. federal cyber posture transitioned from threat warning to operational expectation across three independent vectors within seven days — critical infrastructure isolation (CI Fortify), agentic AI governance (Five Eyes guidance), and healthcare cyber-resilience readiness (AHA – Joint Commission). Iranian OT targeting of U.S. water and energy operators persisted at the elevated baseline established after Operation Epic Fury. DOJ accelerated DPRK IT-worker enforcement to near-monthly cadence with the 7th and 8th laptop-farm sentencing. Perimeter edge-device exploitation continued to dominate the ransomware initial-access vector against Texas mid-market and DIB suppliers. **WHO:** CISA, NSA, FBI, and Five Eyes partner agencies on the federal side. PRC Volt Typhoon and Salt Typhoon clusters as the named pre-positioning threat. Iranian IRGC-affiliated APT actors against OT. DPRK Reconnaissance General Bureau and Lazarus subgroups via the IT-worker scheme and cryptocurrency theft. Akira, Qilin, and The Gentlemen ransomware ecosystems exploiting perimeter devices at industrial scale. **WHY:** Pre-positioning for a future Taiwan or regional crisis (PRC); disruptive retaliation under continuing conflict conditions (Iran); WMD-program revenue generation and sanctions evasion (DPRK); industrialized financial extortion enabled by edge-device exploitation (criminal ecosystems). The geopolitical environment is producing all four pressures simultaneously, and Texas sits at the intersection of every one of them. **WHAT NEXT:** Texas operators should expect federal expectations to harden into sector-specific regulatory language within 12–18 months. CI Fortify becomes the architectural baseline. Agentic AI governance becomes a board-level question. DPRK IT-worker indictments will name a Texas-headquartered firm. The window for posture upgrades on the operator's own timeline is closing. Move now or move on someone else's schedule.

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